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Section Title(S)

Category 1: ego's consanguineous relatives with whom marriage is forbidden • Extension of the incest taboo to four categories • Marriage regulations: the incest taboo and its expression in avoidances

The persons who express in the avoidances the sexual constraint required by the incest taboo are none the less free to engage in other activities of life together. Whether or not they must avoid joking and sitting near each other, whether or not they may marry, they may talk (except with SoWi or DaHu), hunt, share meat, share the water-hole, gather plant foods, cook, eat, make journeys, visit, exchange gifts, and, if they wish, huddle their scherms and fires together. And, although they must not direct sexual jokes or insults to each other, they may laugh as heartily when they overhear the jokes as relatives do who have the joking relationship together.

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Because it is interesting to compare the pattern of the joking relationship with the pattern of marriage regulation, I have indicated it when I list the various categories of persons with whom marriage is forbidden or allowed.

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Extension of the incest taboo to four categories

Marriage regulations, patterned upon the incest taboo as it applies in the relationships of the nuclear family, and extended to certain other relationships because they are considered to be like those of the nuclear family, forbid ego's marriage with four categories of persons, as follows: (1) members of the nuclear family and certain other consanguineous relatives; (2) certain affines;

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(3) step-parents, stepchildren, stepbrothers, stepsisters, and the close kin of ego's father's wife other than his mother (for example, ego's mother's co-wife's sister, who is 'like' his MoSi; (4) certain name relatives.

Category 1: ego's consanguineous relatives with whom marriage is forbidden

In Fig. 2 are listed the consanguineous relatives whom a !Kung must not marry. The terms applied to them are given in their basic form only, all complicating factors being omitted as they have no bearing on marriage regulations. The term which ego applies to the male in a given category appears first; the term applied to females follows. The joking status is indicated by 'yes' if ego has the joking relationship with the given category of relatives, 'no' if he has not.

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The !Kung use the expression 'We are one people' when they refer to certain consanguineous relatives—e.g. any lineal kin and the close collaterals listed in Fig. 2—but they do not consider siblings of grandparents, fourth cousins or still more remote collaterals as being of 'one people' with themselves. The !Kung, who are capable of being pushed to logical conclusions by an interrogator, say that they recognize a degree of consanguinity among such collaterals but spoke of them as 'those people'. 'Those people would name their children for their own people', they said, for example. 'We name our children for our people.'

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I made considerable effort to determine whether or not I should include third cousins as within 'one people'. Many of the informants from whom we gathered genealogical data did not know the names of their third cousins, but, when we established 341 the definition, with sticks and diagrams in the sand and the names of some actual people, Toma, the leader of the band we lived with, insisted that third cousins were 'one's own people'. We 'red people' might marry our own third cousins, he said, but Bushmen would know that they were one people and should not marry.

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